

Board 1

South Deals
None Vul

♠ 8 6 5 3
♥ J 10 9 3
♦ 6 2
♣ 9 7 4

♠ 9

♥ A Q 5

♦ A J 10 8 5 3

♣ K J 6



♠ K Q 10 4 2

♥ K 8 2

♦ 4

♣ 10 8 5 3

♠ A J 7

♥ 7 6 4

♦ K Q 9 7

♣ A Q 2

West	North	East	South
			1NT
Pass	3♦	Pass	4♦
Pass	4♥	Pass	4♠
Pass	6♦		
All Pass			
6♦ by North			
Lead: ♠K			

your suit;

Typically you start showing controls, up the line. So you bid 4♥, showing the ♥A. Partner then bids 4♠.

When partner shows first round ♠ control you know you don't have two quick losers, so you bid 6♦.

North plays 6♦. East leads the ♠K. You win East's opening lead with dummy's ♠A.

Loser List: ♠ = 0 : ♥ = 2 : ♦ = 0 : ♣ = 0 :: Total = 2

You only have one too many losers, and you have a very obvious finesse for the ♥K. But first you pull trumps in two rounds. Do you take the ♥ finesse now?

No you don't. In fact you won't need to take it at all, not with that very valuable ♠J in dummy.

Play a ♣ to dummy's ♣Q, then ruff the ♠7 in your hand. Next play ♣K, then another ♣ to dummy's ♣A. Play the ♠J from dummy and discard your ♥5. East will win this trick, (from the opening lead you knew he had the ♠Q), but he will be end-played. A ♠ or a ♣ will give you a ruff/sluff, but a ♥ will give you a free finesse into your ♥A Q.

There is no doubt that a finesse will save a contract for you sometimes.

Sometimes being about 50% of the time on average.

So whenever you see your contract depending on a finesse, just look again and see if perhaps an elimination play is available.

With 17 points and a 6-card suit you are definitely thinking about slam. The way to suggest slam to partner is to jump in a suit, so you bid 3♦.

Partner says 4♦, bypassing 3NT and agreeing to your suit;

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Board 2

East Deals

None Vul

♠ J 9 4 2

♥ 10 3

♦ 10 9

♣ J 10 9 8 4

♠ A Q 6

♥ 4 2

♦ K J 5 4

♣ K 7 3 2



♠ K 7 3

♥ Q J 9 8 6 5

♦ Q 8 6 2

♣ —

♠ 10 8 5

♥ A K 7

♦ A 7 3

♣ A Q 6 5

West

North

East

South

2♥

2NT

Pass

3NT

All Pass

3NT by South

Lead: ♥10

Over an opponent's Weak 2-bid a 2NT overcall is used to show basically the same as a 1NT opening bid, but promising stopper(s) in their suit.

Partner bids 3NT.

South plays 3NT. West leads the ♥10. As expected, West leads his partner's ♥ suit.

Winner List: ♠ = 1 : ♥ = 2 : ♦ = 2 : ♣ = 3 :: Total = 8

You need only one more winner; the best chance will be a 3-2 split in ♣s. But if that doesn't happen you might have to try the finesse in either ♠s or ♦s. The problem is that both finesses go into the East hand. Because of that fact there is no reason to hold up on the first trick so you win the ♥A. Then you play the ♣A . . . and East discards a ♦!

Don't be sad that the ♣s didn't split, your contract is now guaranteed! Well, guaranteed as long as East has only a 6-card ♥ suit.

Play your ♥K, and when West follows suit play your ♥7. East wins this trick and he can also win 3 more ♥ tricks. But when he runs out of ♥s he will be forced to play a ♠ or a ♦ because he doesn't have any ♣s. Either one will give you your ninth trick.

If the ♣s had split 4-1 you wouldn't know it until you played a second ♣.

But it wouldn't matter, you would still play the same way. As long as you can strip East of any ♣s you can make the throw-in.

Board 3

North Deals

E-W Vul

♠ A 5
♥ Q J 6
♦ K J 9 2
♣ 10 9 5 2

♠ Q J 9 4

♥ A 5 3

♦ A 8

♣ A 8 6 3



♠ K 7 3

♥ K 9 2

♦ 10 7 4

♣ K Q J 4

♠ 10 8 6 2

♥ 10 8 7 4

♦ Q 6 5 3

♣ 7

West	North	East	South
	1NT	Pass	2♣
Pass	2♠		
All Pass			
2♠ by North			
Lead: ♣K			

8

You have a bad hand. Bad, bad, bad hand. But you think playing in ♠s, ♥s or ♦s would be better than playing 1NT. Can you get partner to bid one of those suits? Sure, you just say 2♣. Partner says 2♠. Your call.

You have a bad hand. Bad, bad, bad hand. But you think playing in ♠s, ♥s or ♦s would be better than playing 1NT. Can you get partner to bid one of those suits? Sure, you just say 2♣. Partner says 2♠. Your call.

Your dream just came true. So pass and it won't turn into a nightmare.

The contract would be 2♠ played by South.

North plays 2♠. East leads the ♣K.

Loser List: ♠ = 2 : ♥ = 2 : ♦ = 1 : ♣ = 3 :: Total =

That is a lot of losers. But it makes the plan that much easier. You will try to make as many of dummy's small trumps as you can, and you will do that by ruffing ♣s.

Win the ♣A and ruff a ♣ in dummy. Return to your hand with the ♦A and ruff another ♣. Back to your hand with the ♥A and ruff another ♣.

You have taken 6 tricks already and cannot be prevented from winning two more trumps.

Making those small trumps by ruffing was a pretty obvious play.

Lucky for you the defenders didn't see the advantage of playing three rounds of trumps right off the bat.

It would be tough for East to come up with a ♠ lead from ♠ K 7 3, but it would have been great defense.

Board 4

South Deals

None Vul

♠ Q 8 2

♥ 9

♦ K 9 7 4

♣ K Q J 9 2

♠ K 6 3

♥ A K J 2

♦ 8 5 2

♣ 7 6 4



♠ 10 9 5 4

♥ 10 7 5 3

♦ J 10 3

♣ 8 5

♠ A J 7

♥ Q 8 6 4

♦ A Q 6

♣ A 10 3

West

North

East

South

1NT

Pass

3NT

All Pass

3NT by South

Lead: ♣K

get the lead.

Nonetheless it is a good idea to hold up - **but only once**.

West then plays the ♣Q which you win as East follows. Next you run four ♥ tricks, ending in dummy. You play dummy's ♠K, your sixth trick so far. It is crunch time. Do you now finesse for the ♦K or the ♠Q?

The answer is NO, you do not take either finesse. Instead you play a ♣, hoping West must take the trick. And he does. West then cashes two more ♣ tricks but then he is out of ♣s. Since he is also out of ♥s he is going to have to play either a ♠ or a ♦, either one of which will make you very happy!

The reason for holding up on the first ♣ but taking the second was to keep your options open for the endplay.

If East had not followed to the second ♣ you might not have been able to use the endplay. Instead you would have run the ♥s, and if West did not discard a ♣, you would have to guess as to which finesse to try. With the cards as shown neither would have worked.

Holding a 4-card ♥ suit some bidders would use Stayman. However, when you have 4-3-3-3 distribution there is little chance of ruffing so others prefer not to use Stayman. You take the latter view and bid 3NT with your 11 points.

The contract would be 3NT played by North.

South plays 3NT. West leads the ♣K and East follows with the ♣5.

Do you hold up? If so, how many times?

Winner List: ♠ = 2 : ♥ = 4 : ♦ = 1 : ♣ = 1 :: Total = 8

Your ninth trick will be either the ♠J or the ♦Q. In both cases the finesse would be into the West hand so the question of disrupting opponent's communications doesn't arise - East is not going to

Board 5

North Deals

N-S Vul

♠ J 10 5
♥ Q J 10 2
♦ Q 5 4
♣ K 8 6

♠ A 6

♥ K 7 4

♦ A J 9 3

♣ A 9 7 4



♠ 7 3

♥ A 9 5 3

♦ 8 7 6

♣ Q J 10 2

♠ K Q 9 8 4 2

♥ 8 6

♦ K 10 2

♣ 5 3

West	North	East	South
	1NT	Pass	2♥
Pass	2♠	Pass	4♠
All Pass			
4♠ by North			
Lead: ♣Q			

♦Q? and if so, which way do you finesse?

Missing 6 ♦s to the Queen of course you should finesse. And you will finesse through West, of course, because he is the Danger Hand. So play dummy's ♦K, then play the ♦10 and let it ride.

This time West holds the ♦Q and you make an overtrick, winning 4 ♦ tricks and discarding a ♥ loser from dummy.

Another time East will hold the ♦Q and you will make the contract, but no overtrick.

Partner transfers and you naturally respond 2♠.

Partner bids the ♠ game and you pass.

North plays 4♠. East leads the ♣Q. West plays the ♣8 and your first decision is whether to hold up.

Loser List: ♠ = 0 : ♥ = 2 : ♦ = 1 : ♣ = 1 :: Total = 4

You should certainly hold up. West is the Danger hand here because if West ever gets the lead he can play a ♥ through your unprotected ♥K, possibly giving you two ♥ losers. If you take the first trick with the ♣A you open the door for West to gain entry with the ♣K which you know he has.

Next pull three rounds of trumps. Fortune smiles and they split 3-2.

Now it's time to play on ♦s. Do you finesse for the